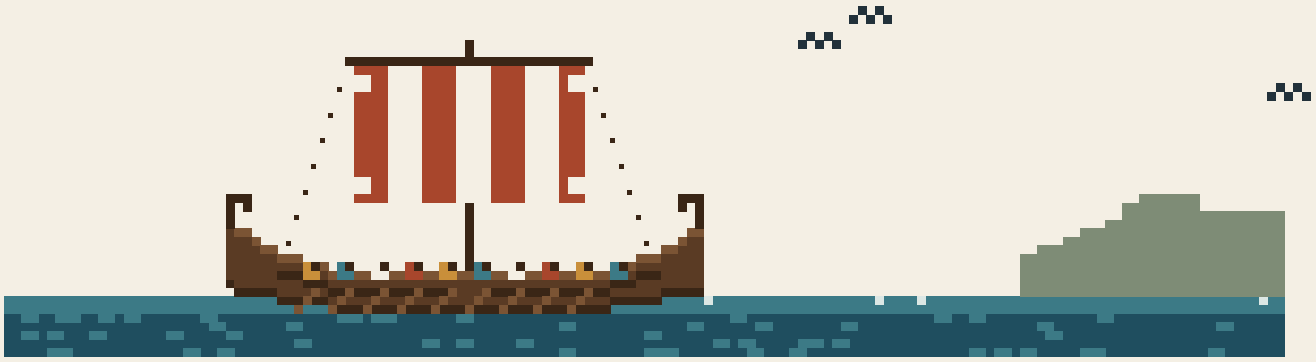
OAR AND EMBER

07 / Ship and Visual Reference Guide

Vessel progression, customisation, settlement appearance and pixel-art rules.



The ship and the steading are the two places the player looks at most. Both should visibly carry every decision the player has made: patched planks, a chosen sail, a smoke-house that was not there last winter.

HOW TO USE THIS SET

This book owns art detail and ship appearance. Final art is authored by Claude to these rules (section 11). Book 1's pixel-art contract is locked and overrides this book. Book 2 owns the manifest format and data types; Book 10 owns every number, including the ship statistics repeated here for reference.

Specification. Dimensions and statistics are starting values for balancing. Historical ship types are used loosely for flavour and are not claims of archaeological accuracy.

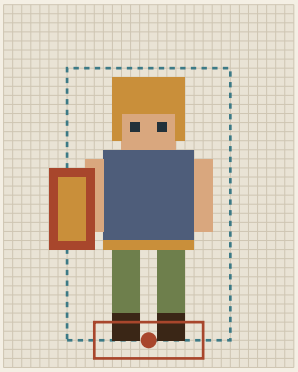
IN THIS BOOK

01 / Art baseline 2
02 / Vessel progression 3
03 / Fittings and customisation 4
04 / Identity and cosmetics 5
05 / Ship sprites and states 6
06 / Settlement appearance 7
07 / People sprites 8
08 / Palette, light and weather 9
09 / Supernatural visual language 10
10 / Interface and sea map style 11
11 / Asset manifest, naming and art QA 11
12 / Blood and gore 12
13 / Wilderness and exploration art 13

01 / Art baseline

A single coherent pixel scale for every asset. No mixing of old canvases with new ones.

Item	Specification
Renderer	WebGL2, nearest-neighbour textures, no filtering or mipmaps on pixel art
Logical viewport	640 x 360 logical pixels; integer scaling to the screen; letterbox, never stretch
World tile	24 x 24 logical pixels; about 1.4 m in world terms
Adult sprite	32 x 40 canvas, about 18 x 30 occupied, foot anchor at bottom centre
Sampling	Nearest-neighbour; all positions snapped to whole logical pixels at draw time
Depth	Sort by foot anchor Y; tall objects provide an occlusion line and a cutaway or fade
Facings	Four authored facings for people; armed sprites are never mirrored
UI text	May render on an accessible overlay at native resolution, never blurred into the pixel layer
Sea map	Separate 16 x 16 tile set with ship tokens; never shown at the local-scene scale



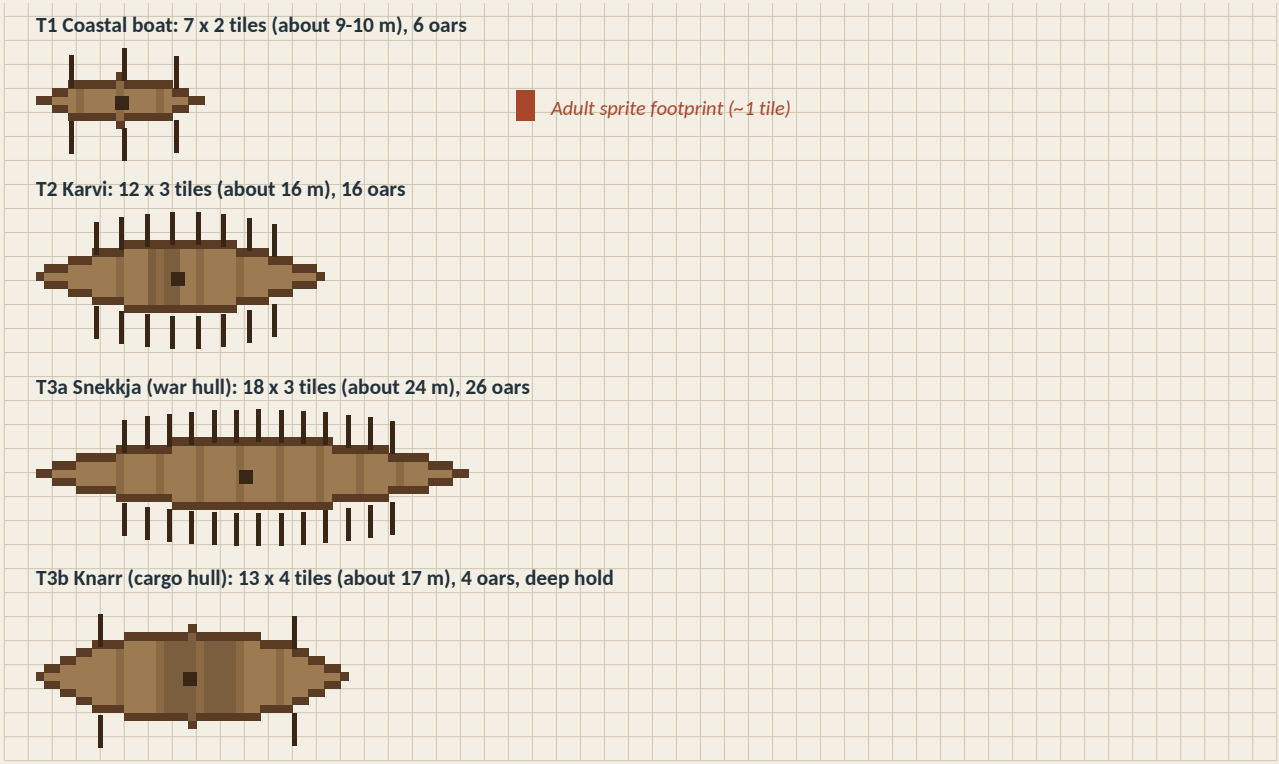
Canvas	32 x 40 logical px
Occupied body	about 18 x 30 px (dashed)
Foot anchor	bottom centre (dot); sorts depth
Collision	12 x 4 px ellipse at feet (red box)
Facings	4 authored (S, N, E, W); never mirror armed sprites
Core states	idle, walk, run, attack, block, dodge, hurt, carry, row, downed
Readability	shield stays on the left arm in every facing

Animation targets

Idle 4 frames, walk 6, run 8, sneak 6, light attacks 5 to 7 each with a clear tell frame, charge hold 4 (looping, with a glint at level 1 and a stronger flash at level 2), heavy release 6, parry 3, riposte 5, block 3, guard broken 3, stagger 3, dodge 4, shove 4, hurt 2, finisher 8, carry walk 6, row 4, downed 2, surrendered 2, and a work loop of 4 to 8 frames for every homestead task. Fewer readable frames are acceptable in early stages if the tell, active and recovery frames are distinct. Animation events (hit start, hit end, footstep, oar catch) live in the manifest and must agree with collision and damage timing.

02 / Vessel progression

One ship that grows: a repaired coastal boat, a karvi, then a choice between a war hull and a cargo hull. A second vessel can be owned from Chapter 6 but is managed only on the sea map.



Scale grid: one square = one 24 px world tile. Local scenes draw hulls at true tile length; sea-map tokens use the smaller icon set.

Tier	Length	Tiles	Oars	Berths	Rowing crew	Cargo	Draft	Sea	Oar / Sail
T1 Coastal boat	9 to 10 m	7 x 2	6	8	4	4	Shallow	2	2 / 3
T2 Karvi	16 m	12 x 3	16	18	10	10	Shallow	3	3 / 4
T3a Snekkja	24 m	18 x 3	26	30	16	8	Medium	3	5 / 4
T3b Knarr	17 m	13 x 4	4	10	4	24	Deep	5	1 / 4

Sea is seaworthiness from 1 to 5. **Oar / Sail** are relative speeds from 1 to 5. **Rowing crew** is the minimum to row at full speed; fewer rowers reduce oar speed proportionally. Berths beyond the household's residents are filled by hired oarsmen or allied warriors, who do not count against the roster of sixteen.

How hulls are acquired

Hull	Ways to get it	Chapter
T1 Coastal boat	Repaired on Wreck Strand	1
T2 Karvi	Bought from Gunnhild's yard; captured from a rival; or built in the Skarvholm boatshed over winter (timber, iron, Runa)	3 to 4
T3a Snekkja or T3b Knarr	Commissioned at Saltvik; captured from Orm's fleet; or built on the mainland	5 to 7
Consort	A second T2 or T3b, owned and crewed but sailed only on the sea map	6 onwards

Continuity: what transfers to a new hull

The **name**, **sail mark**, **stem and stern carvings**, **trophies**, the **ship's history log** and up to two **fittings** carry over. The old hull can be sold, kept as the consort, broken for timber, or given to an ally as a gift. The crew should feel they moved house, not bought a different ship.

The ship's history log

Every notable event is recorded against the ship: launches, raids, battles survived, storms ridden, famous passengers, damage taken and repaired. The log feeds dialogue ("the boat that came back from the Cauldron"), harbour reactions and the endings.

03 / Fittings and customisation

Every fitting is a trade-off with a visible change on the hull. A good ship reflects a plan, not a shopping list.

Slots

T1 has three slots (bow, midship, stern). T2 has five (bow, two midship, stern, rig). T3 hulls have six. Hull modifications (draft, strength) are refits that use no slot but take days in a boatshed and materials.

Fitting	Slot	Benefit	Drawback	On the sprite
Extended hold	Midship	+2 cargo (+1 on T1)	Oar speed -1; rowing crew +1	Hides and sacks under lashings
Raised bow platform	Bow	Better boarding defence; archers gain range	Cargo -1	Timber platform at the bow
Shield rack	Gunwale (free on T2+)	Missile cover when shields are up; intimidation	Reveals identity; shields can be lost	Shields along the gunwale
Grapnels and boarding planks	Stern	Faster, safer boarding	Cargo -1	Coiled lines, a plank lashed aft
Awning and stores	Midship	+4 days of stores; rest at sea heals light wounds	Cargo -1	Wadmal awning on spars
Bailing station	Midship	Storm and hull damage reduced	Cargo -1	Buckets, a bailing well
Towing gear	Stern	Tow a captured boat for extra cargo	Speed -1 while towing	Tow line and bollard
Better sail and rigging	Rig	Sail speed +1; better against the wind	Needs a skilled shipwright to maintain	Brighter cloth, more lines
Carved beast-head	Bow (identity)	Intimidation bonus	Must be unshipped at friendly shores or land-spirits and locals take offence	A carved head on the stem
Gilt weather-vane	Mast (identity)	Trade prestige; wind forecast improves	Costly; very recognisable	A gilt vane catching light

Hull refits

Refit	Benefit	Cost
Shallow draft	Loch, river and shallow landings	Seaworthiness -1; capacity -1
Doubled strakes	Hull integrity +30%	Oar speed -1; timber and iron
Re-caulking	Removes accumulated leaks	Tar, moss and two days

Maintenance

Fittings and hulls wear. A shipwright resident keeps them in order as delegated work; without one, wear accumulates and is explained in the report ("the rigging is fraying; Runa could fix it in a day"). Nothing breaks without warning.

04 / Identity and cosmetics

How the coast recognises the household, and how the player chooses to be recognised.

Sail marks

Sails are woven in panels and can be dyed. Patterns: plain undyed wool, broad stripes, narrow stripes, lozenge checks, quartered, or a single device (raven, serpent, wave, cross, sun-wheel). Dyes are madder red, woad blue, weld yellow and undyed. Changing a sail takes cloth, dye and time at a yard.

Example	Owner	What it says
Black with a raven	Ulf Hrafnsson	Raiders; expect killing
Grey, plain	Orm's fleet	The Sea King's tribute ships
Red and white stripes	Saltvik traders	Merchants; usually peaceful
Undyed with a blue cross	Kilbrecc's boats	Church; sanctuary claimed
Player's choice	The household	Chosen at the launch in Chapter 1

Shields, carvings and trophies

Shield colours come in sets of two or three. Stem and stern carvings range from a plain curl to a beast-head. Trophies are earned and displayed: a captured enemy vane, a Glen Arra cattle bell, a piece of the lyngbakr's heather, the Ferryman's lamp-hook. Each trophy has an entry in the history log.

Damage and repair

Damage shows as splintered strakes, torn sail panels and missing shields. Repairs leave visible patches in newer timber and cloth for the rest of the hull's life. A ship that has been through a lot should look like it.

Identification

Recognition depends on what a witness could see: sail and device from far away, shields and carvings closer, faces and voices ashore. Repainting or changing a sail lowers identification on future deeds, not past ones, and costs some reputation with those who knew the old mark.

05 / Ship sprites and states

Ships in local scenes are walkable places built from modular segments, drawn at true tile length.

Construction

Hulls are built from segments: **bow**, a repeatable **midship** segment (one per three to four tiles of length) and **stern**. The deck is a walkable layer with benches, mast step, cargo spaces and gunwale. Each tier has its own segment set; segments are never stretched.

States

System	States
Sail	Furled, half, full, reefed, torn, struck
Oars	Shipped, out, stroke (4 frames), backing, tangled
Hull	Sound, damaged (three visible levels), holed, beached, sinking
Loading	Each cargo lot shown as a sack, barrel, bale, chest or pen in its slot
Crew	Rowing, idle, bailing, shields up, boarding, wounded resting
Identity	Sail mark, shields, carvings, vane, trophies

Beaching, launching and boarding

Beaching shows the hull tilting onto shingle; launching shows the crew pushing and climbing aboard, part of the extraction in raids. Boarding planks and grapnel lines are drawn objects with collision. When two ships are lashed, their decks form one walkable area with a readable gap.

Sea-map tokens

Each tier has a 16 x 16 or 24 x 16 token with eight headings, a sail-state frame, a wake and the household's sail colour. Fog dims tokens; unknown ships show a neutral sail until identified.

06 / Settlement appearance

The steading and the mainland home are the player's progress made visible. Each culture builds differently, and those differences should read at a glance.

Skarvholm stages

Stage	Appearance
S0 Wreck camp	A fire on the shingle, a lean-to from the torn sail, salvage in heaps above the tide line
S1 Broch shelter	Sail roof stretched across the broch's interior, hearth smoke, drying lines, a driftwood door
S2 Steading	A turf-walled longhouse with curved sides, a naust boatshed, fish racks, a small forge, a byre, the residents' shrine
S3 Prosperous	Carved door posts, a smoke-house, a second house, the watch cairn on Rook Hill, coloured cloth, benches outside
S4 Failing	Salt rime on the Kelda stones, a slumped landing, water standing in the field, emptied racks
S5 Outpost	One house and the watch cairn kept, or a respectful ruin with a marker for the dead
S6 Occupied	Late game: a stake palisade round the broch, grey banners, the burned boatshed, the longhouse as a barracks, beaches drowned to tidal flats, salt rime on the Kelda, sea-light at the cairn dig

Mainland home stages

Stage	Appearance
M0 Camp	Tents and stacked timber inside a marked line; the ship drawn up on the strand
M1 Hall	A longhouse and boatshed; first fields; fences
M2 Defended home	Ditch, palisade, gate, watch platform, a landing jetty
M3 United home	A hall with guest benches for allies, a shared shrine with more than one sign of faith, a market strand

Architectural languages

Culture or place	Buildings	Read at a glance by
Gaelic farms and ringforts	Roundhouses with conical thatch inside an earthen bank and ditch; a royal rath on a crag at Dún Fiach	Circles: round walls, round enclosures
Kilbrecc monastery	A tall round tower, a small stone church, a high cross, an enclosure wall, a guesthouse	The tower's silhouette
Norse households	Long rectangular houses with curved walls and turf or thatch roofs; boatsheds	Long low lines and boat shapes
Saltvik	Rectangular post-and-wattle houses in plots, plank walkways, jetties, a yard with hulls on stocks	Density and timber walkways
Glen Arra	Mixed: longhouses and shielings, cattle folds, a smithy with a cross and a hammer on the lintel	Cattle and mixed signs
Inis Rón	Low stone cells, seal rocks, carved standing stones, kelp drying	Seals and stone
Kaldness	A stockaded hall above a crowded harbour of grey sails	Grey sails, high timber walls

Designation and construction

A designated building appears as a dithered blueprint in undyed tones; cells that break a placement rule tint red with the reason shown in text. Construction has three visible stages (marked out, framed, finished) with material piles beside the plot. Residents use task-specific work animations at each station, so the player can watch a roof go on or a keel being shaped.

Interiors

Buildings use roof cutaways or fades when the player enters. Hearths are the warm centre of every interior. A prosperous home shows hangings, carved benches, chests and clutter; a struggling one shows bare benches and cold corners.

07 / People sprites

People are distinguished by silhouette, clothing and carried tools, not by colour alone.

Cultural silhouettes

Group	Typical clothing and gear
Norse household	Knee-length tunic, trousers with wrap leg-bindings, cloak pinned at the shoulder, round shield, spear or axe; leaders may have mail and a plain rounded helmet
Gaelic farmers and warriors	Long linen tunic, a heavy rectangular cloak with a brooch, spears and small shields; riders on small horses
Monks	Undyed habits, the Insular tonsure shaved at the front of the head, satchels and staffs
Norse-Gaelic people	Mixed: Gaelic cloaks over Norse tunics, Norse brooches on Gaelic dress, both kinds of weapon
Keepers of Inis Rón	Seal-skin cloaks, bone and shell ornaments, bare feet on stone
Orm's men	Grey cloaks, more mail and helmets than anyone else, disciplined spacing

The steerer's body models

Two body models, A and B, offered side by side without labels. Both share the full animation set, every clothing, hair and gear option, and the same collision footprint. Nothing in art or text names a gender.

Rules

- No horned helmets. No generic fantasy plate. No modern props.
- Residents differ by silhouette, hair, clothing and the tool they carry (Runa's adze, Bran's ladle, Áine's bow).
- Faction markers use shape and clothing as well as colour.
- Ally, enemy, surrendered and downed actors are distinguishable without relying on colour: surrendered actors kneel with empty hands; downed actors lie flat; enemies carry their weapon on the far side; allies show a small shape-coded marker when selected.
- Readable at 1x and 2x scale.

08 / Palette, light and weather

Grey-green sea, heather and machair, weathered timber, warm hearths, and restrained colour in cloth.

SEA AND SKY

- Deep sea #1F4E5F
- Shallows #3C7A86
- Swell #4F8B95
- Foam / mist #DCE7E4
- Overcast #8FA7AE
- Night water #2B3B4A

LAND AND TIMBER

- Machair grass #8C9A7A
- Heather #5F6E4E
- Shingle #9A8B6E
- Tarred oak #5A3B24
- New timber #7B5434
- Pitch / shadow #3A2616

CLOTH AND HEARTH

- Madder red #A8462C
- Ochre / hearth #C98F3A
- Undyed wool #E7D7B5
- Woad blue #4E5D7A
- Weld-green #6E7F4C
- Bleached linen #F4EFE4

RESERVED ACCENTS

- Sea-light (Rán) #7FD6C9
- Sídhe glamour #C9B8E0
- Corpse-light #E9F0A0
- Danger tell #D23C2C
- Hit flash #FFFFFF
- Outline ink #22313A

Light

Day is cool and clear; dusk warms the land and darkens the sea; night uses lantern and hearth pools with the rest of the scene readable in blue shadow. Fire and hearth are the warmest colours in the game. Reserved accents (sea-light, sídhe glamour, corpse-light, danger tell) never appear in ordinary scenery.

Weather

Rain is a light overlay that never hides an actionable threat. Fog uses layered dithering and reduces sight ranges in the simulation, not only visually. Storm scenes add spray, tilt the horizon a pixel or two and darken the palette, but threats and the ship's edge remain readable.

09 / Supernatural visual language

The supernatural begins as one wrong detail. Only important phenomena earn strong luminous colour.

Power	First wrong detail	Full manifestation
Rán	Ripples moving against the current	Pale green sea-light below the surface; nets of light; the drowned standing in the shallows
Manannán	Fog moving against the wind	A grey-cloaked figure in a small boat; foam shaped like horses
The Cailleach	Frost on one stone only	A hag-shaped cloud over the Cauldron; hail out of season
The Blue Men	Blue shapes in the wave troughs	Blue-skinned figures riding the swell, speaking verse
Aos sí and landvættir	Flowers out of season; shadows falling the wrong way	Tall figures at the edge of light, too still
Draugr	Wet footprints with no one there	Dripping figures hung with weed, colder palette, no gore
Fetch and fylgja	A resident's double one step behind them, slightly desaturated	An animal that follows one person and no one else
Washer at the ford	A woman kneeling at a stream at dawn	Shirts in her hands that belong to named residents
Each-uisce	A fine horse standing in the shallows, mane wet	Weed in the mane; it walks into deep water
Lyngbakr	An island with no birds and no surf	The "island" tilting and sliding under
The Long Swimmer	A wake behind the ship with nothing making it	A long back breaking the surface far off
The Door of Three Truths	Carvings that seem to listen; dust that settles when someone lies	A seam of pale light opening down the stone
Manannán's Cup	A plain grey cup that holds no reflection	Mist rising from it; the sea-light around it dims

Supernatural actors still obey collision, visibility and attack timing unless a specific signalled ability says otherwise.

10 / Interface and sea map style

The interface should feel like wood, cloth and carved bone, and stay easy to read.

- Panels use simple framed borders in timber and wool colours; text sits on calm backgrounds with high contrast.
- The sea map shows coasts, known routes, wind and tide indicators, fog, known threats and the household's token. Unknown places show as coastline only until discovered.
- Icons are shape-coded (a wave for tide, an arrow for wind, a sail for ships, a cross, hammer or stone for sacred places).
- Text size is adjustable; all speech is subtitled; colour-blind presets swap reserved accents without changing shape cues.
- The steward's morning report and the post-raid summary use plain sentences, not percentages.

11 / Asset manifest, naming and art QA

Every asset is listed in a manifest with its frames, pivot, footprint and events. Book 2 owns the schema.

Naming

Asset type	Pattern	Example
Person	`actor_<id>_<state>_<facing>`	`actor_c_hild_walk_s`
Ship segment	`ship_<tier>_<part>_<state>`	`ship_t2_mid_damaged2`
Ship token	`token_<tier>_<heading>_<sail>`	`token_t1_ne_full`
Tile	`tile_<biome>_<variant>`	`tile_machair_03`
Building	`bld_<culture>_<type>_<stage>`	`bld_norse_longhouse_s3`
Effect	`fx_<power>_<name>`	`fx_ran_sealight`

The art pipeline: authored by Claude

- **Palette file:** the Book 7 palette plus blood reds, as indexed colours; sources may use only these indices.
- **Sources:** one text file per sheet: frame size, frame list, and each frame as rows of single-character palette codes, with pivot, footprint and animation events. Deterministic generator scripts are allowed for tiles and variations and are committed with their output.
- **Style rules:** one-pixel ink outline on characters and props (not on terrain); light from the upper left; three-tone ramps per material (shadow, base, highlight) plus a fourth for metal glints; ordered dithering only for fog, mist and gradients in sky and water.
- **Compile and check:** the art compiler packs atlases and manifests. Claude renders every new or changed sheet at 1x and 4x, inspects the images against these rules, and records the check in the stage report.
- **Review:** the user reviews art at each build gate; changes requested there are logged and applied before the next gate.

Placeholder rules for LLM-built stages

- Never replace missing art with permanent circles, boxes or emoji.
- Temporary silhouettes are allowed only with `placeholder: true` in the manifest and a line in the stage report.
- Placeholders are replaced before the art gate in Book 3.

Art QA checklist

- All sprites snap to whole logical pixels at 1x, 2x and 3x scale.
- Foot anchors and collision footprints agree; no sliding feet.
- Attack tells precede active frames by at least 6 ticks at normal combat speed.
- Ally, enemy, surrendered and downed actors are distinguishable in greyscale.
- Night, fog and rain never hide an actionable threat.
- Ship states are complete for every tier in use; no stretched segments.
- Every reserved accent appears only where this book allows it.

12 / Blood and gore

The game is for adults. Violence should look costly and ugly, drawn in the same pixel language as everything else.

Elements

Element	Specification
Blood palette	Fresh `#B32424`, dark `#8E1B1B`, dried `#5A0F12`, highlight `#D9483B`
Hit spray	4 to 10 particles of 1 to 2 px, direction from the blow, heavier for heavy and riposte hits
Decals	Drops, pools under the downed and dead, smears and drag trails when bodies or wounded are carried
Bloodied state	Overlay on actors below half vitality; clothing darkens at the wound side
Dismemberment	Separate pieces (arm, leg, head) for killing blows from heavy cutting weapons; pieces bounce once and settle; the body uses a matching corpse pose
Corpses	A corpse pose per facing for each body type and animal; corpses persist for the scene and, at home, until buried or burned
Animals	Wolves, boar, cattle, sheep and seals bleed and leave carcasses that can be butchered

The gore setting

Full: everything above. **Low:** no dismemberment, fewer and darker decals, corpses fade after a minute. **Off:** no blood, hit flashes only, corpses fade. The setting changes presentation only; deeds and consequences are identical.

Restraint where it matters

Gore serves weight, not spectacle. There are no slow-motion kill cameras and no rewards for gore. Children never appear as actors, so they never appear in violence.

13 / Wilderness and exploration art

On-foot exploration needs varied, readable ground that changes with the seasons.

Tile sets

Set	Contents
Island coast	Shingle, sand, tidal flats with wet sheen, skerries, kelp, cliffs with climbable ledges, sea caves with tide marks
Machair and moor	Machair grass and flowers, heather, bracken, peat banks and cuttings, bog pools, plank roads
Woodland	Oakwood and pinewood floors, trunks with occlusion, undergrowth that hides sneaking actors, clearings
Upland	Corrie walls, scree, high pasture, shieling huts, summit cairns
Waters	Lake shore, river fords, holy well, salt pans
Sites	Stone rings, burial mounds, ringfort banks, souterrain and cairn interiors, the hermit's cell

Seasons and weather

Every outdoor set has four seasonal variants: spring green with flowers, summer full and dry, autumn bracken-brown with fallen leaves, winter frost, snow patches and ice on bog pools. Weather overlays (rain, fog, snow) follow Book 7 section 08 and never hide an actionable threat.

Interactive and puzzle objects

Anything the player can climb, pull, light, read, align or take has a consistent one-pixel highlight edge when in range. Hand-holds on climbable cliffs are drawn, not implied. Puzzle objects show their state visually (a stone's shadow, a water line, an unlit brazier).

Wildlife

Wolf, boar, red deer, hare, seal, otter, gulls, cormorants, a sea eagle, sheep and small black cattle, each with four facings and the states they need (walk, run, attack or flee, eat, sleep, dead).